party's Hindu traditionalists on the question of Hinduism and its role in the new India.

The debate eventually ended with the Union government instituting new curbs on foreign missionaries in 1955. They would henceforth be required to take prior government approval to enter India, and would not be welcome if they devoted themselves only to proselytisation. They would also need to have suitable qualifications in fields like education, medicine and social work.[42] It was only after this new regulation that Rajendra Prasad issued a new and reassuring statement to foreign missionaries. Speaking at a function to celebrate the 1,903rd anniversary of the arrival of St Thomas in India, the president of India said that the country had 'no intention of curtailing their freedom or come in the way of their missions'.[43] It was in this political atmosphere that the ABVKA was born.

Hanuman Statues and Jagrans vs Missionaries: ABVKA's Early Strategies

While the president and the prime minister jousted, in Madhya Pradesh, Chief Minister Shukla appointed two enquiry commissions on religious conversions. The first one, headed by former Madhya Bharat High Court judge M.B. Rege, announced that 1,200 conversions had taken place in the state since Independence.[44] The second and better known Justice M. Bhavani Shankar Niyogi-led 'Christian Missionary Activities Enquiry Committee' (1954–1956) was even more scathing. It recommended a forced withdrawal of missionary activity and the takeover of foreign mission properties by what it called 'national churches' or to an 'international holding body', arguing that:[45]

Evangelism in India appears to be part of the uniform world policy to revive Christendom for re-establishing western supremacy and it is not prompted by spiritual motives. The objective is apparently to create Christian minority pockets with a view to disrupting the solidity of non-Christian societies, and the mass conversions of a